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'No more work at the mine'

—Irvine Shipland photo

Rick Robertson . . . he was lucky

Scramble for Jobs Pays Off for 29 From Jordan River

By AL FORREST
Times Staff

It was just three months ago that Rick Robertson was preparing to go to work on the night shift when the call came.

"They will be no further work at the Jordan River mine until further notice," he was told.

And that was that.

The mine was closed.

"It was a very unhappy time with the layoff coming like that, just before Christmas," he recalled today.

However, after six weeks without work and without income he found a job in Victoria, through Canada Manpower.

"I guess I was lucky," he said. "I was about to move to Calgary to try and find work there."

Robertson, 25, is one of 29 former Jordan River miners to find employment in B.C. since the December shutdown.

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In all, 74 men were laid off when the mine closed, 63 in December and 11 in an earlier layoff.

Six moved out of B.C., 12 took retraining programs through Canada Manpower and the remaining 29 are still looking for work.

The job search is being coordinated by a temporary organization called Jordan River Manpower. The Sooke office, paid for by Canada Manpower, is run by Jack Burns, former Jordan River mine shift boss, assisted by Cliff Lane, another former Jordan River miner.

"We have been able to assist the men in a number of ways," Burns said.

"We find work for some, retraining for others and we have been able to collect about 20 per cent in the back wages owed when the mine closed. We are trying to collect the rest.

Jordan River Mines owed the men more than $80,000 when the mine closed and the company went into receivership. About $30,000 is still owing.

Burns said Jordan River Manpower is trying to arrange for a sale of the mine equipment to bring in the rest of the back wages.

Most of the 29 men who found employment are working in other B.C. mines. Four are working in Texada Island mine, several are in northern B.C.

Three are still employed at Jordan River, guarding the mine machinery on behalf of the sheriff's office. At least two found work in the Victoria area — one at the airport and Robertson, who works in the shipping department of Precision Engines and Parts Ltd.

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Robertson has collected about 18 per cent of the $630 he was owed when the mine closed.

"I went six weeks without a pay cheque. It was pretty grim but things are better now that I'm working again."

Robertson was born in Victoria and was delighted that he was able to stay. He continues to rent a small cottage in Sooke.

"The drive isn't too bad. It used to take 25 minutes to get out to Jordan River. It only takes about 23 minutes to drive into Victoria — if I time it right."

He said it can take the better part of an hour if he had to back the rush hour traffic around 7:30 a.m. He waits until 8:30 a.m. He drives home after the 4 p.m. rush.

Meanwhile, two ex-miners who will soon be looking for work again are Burns and Lane of the Jordan River Manpower office.

"This is just a temporary office to help the men get re-established," Burns said.

"Our budget will run out soon . . . possibly by the end of this month."

Gunman Gets 6 Years

Frank Guiney was sentenced in county court today to six years in the penitentiary for armed robbery at the Criterion Club on Yates Street last September.

Judge Montague Drake said the sentence would have been longer but for the chance of reformation mentioned in a pre-sentence report.

Guiney, 42, of 384 Owings, was found guilty Feb. 12 of holding up the Criterion Club Sept. 5 and robbing two card players of $1,245.

The court was told earlier that there were eight card players at the club when two masked men entered and ordered the players to lie on the floor.

One of the card players, George Dekker, testified earlier that after club manager Les Hanson wrestled one masked man to the floor he pulled off the ski mask, had a good look at the person pinned to the floor and identified Guiney in court as that person.

While Hanson wrestled the man to the floor, a sawed-off shotgun discharged but no one was injured.

Guiney was accused of robbing Hanson of $1,566 and William Winter, another card player, of $145.

The crown earlier entered a stay of proceedings against a second man charged in connection with the robbery.

Guiney himself took the stand during the trial and told the jury he had no recollection of anything between 8 p.m. Sept. 5, the day of the robbery, and 1 a.m. Sept. 6 when he woke up in the hospital.

He said he had had a lot to drink and had taken some valium, a tranquilizer.

During Guiney's bail hearing last year in provincial court, he was described as "one of Canada's greatest living poets," by National Film Board director Steven Regimbald.

A-G's WIFE TO PAY

Attorney-General Alex Macdonald's wife is going to be stuck with paying the fine he received for driving without valid licence plate decals.

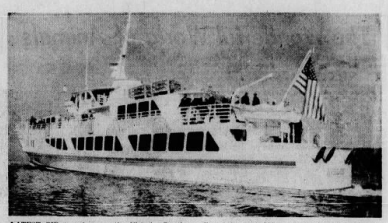
Named MLA Jiles Chabot (Columbia) raised the matter in the legislature Wednesday and asked whether the government might be paying the $10 ticket given to the minister Wednesday when he was driving a government car to work.

Macdonald said his department has taken full blame for the slip-up with the decals and wants to pay the fine.

"But I can no way — my wife will pay," he said.

Chabot also questioned the amount of the fine and Macdonald said he should pay no different amount because of his position.

Victoria city police said if a person has the decals but has failed to display them the penalty is $10; if he hasn't the decals the penalty is $25 plus $200 for no insurance.



LATEST BID to take over the Victoria - Seattle ferry run is from three American businessmen who propose using the 180-foot aluminum ship Avalon, built at Tacoma in 1971. She has a U.S. coastguard licence to carry 510 passengers. Spokesman Tom Orr of Long Beach, Calif., was in Victoria Thursday to try and line up docking facilities. Docking facilities at Seattle are already confirmed.

Victoria Times
FRIDAY, MARCH 7, 1975 15
SECOND SECTION

Minister Challenged On Jubilee Bed Move

Health Minister Dennis Cocke said today he has asked Royal Jubilee Hospital to temporarily assign 70 beds in Memorial Pavilion for extended care patients.

While Cocke said the move will bring immediate relief to a lengthy list of patients waiting for extended care beds, the hospital said it will result in nothing more than reshuffling of patients at the expense of those needing acute care.

Both the Memorial Pavilion, formerly Veterans' Hospital, and the rest of Jubilee are already full, said executive director A. C. Pickles.

And the hospital has a list of about 1,200 people waiting for an acute care bed, meaning some will be waiting up to three months.

Extended care beds are for chronically ill, mostly elderly people, who require nursing rather than acute hospital care. Throughout the Capital district, there is a waiting period from two to five months for patients qualifying for extended care.

Both Jubilee and Victoria General Hospital have pointed out repeatedly in recent months that many of their expensive acute care beds are occupied by patients needing only extended care because there is no place else for these patients to go.

There are an estimated 90 patients at Jubilee and another 50 to 60 at Victoria General today who do not need the acute care beds they are occupying. Together they could fill a 150-bed addition scheduled to start at Glengarry extended care hospital this year.

Cocke's announcement comes six days after word that Aberdeen private hospital in Victoria will close at the end of May, forcing 77 elderly and ailing patients there to find care elsewhere.

The health minister suggested earlier this week that announcement by Aberdeen owner Neil de Macedo of the closing was possibly "a business play" in purchase negotiations with the government.

At Jubilee, Pickles said that all of the 221 beds in the Memorial Pavilion are filled, for all practical purposes. Of these, 110 are exclusively for the care of veterans needing other than acute care and another 60 throughout the hospital are reserved for veterans needing acute care.

The change asked by Cocke will have the effect of grouping extended care patients now scattered throughout the hospital, said Pickles, and that will produce a more efficient nursing situation.

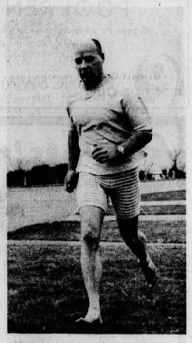
The hospital is prepared to go along with the move but all it results in is a regrouping of patients already occupying hospital beds.

Murder Appeal

The appeal of Jorg Walter Berger, found guilty last May of murdering Raymond Beckett, will be heard by the B.C. Appeal Court April 28-29 in Victoria.

The appeal was to have been heard Feb. 28 at the Appeal Court in Vancouver but was rescheduled.

Berger, an Austrian student, was convicted of killing Burkett, 41, of 4980 Lochside, by stabbing him. Burkett was found by a passerby in Walker Park, Oak Bay.



BAREFOOT IN THE PARK — well, on Dallas Road boulevard, to be exact — is more than just a book and movie title for 40-year-old Mervyn Greer, city parks department employee and CUPE member. Shoeless Greer, who normally keeps the boulevards trim and tidy, logs six miles daily during the current strike-lockout. Maybe he figures that's one way to help keep the grass short. (Bill Halfort Photo)

Top Men of CUPE Hold Talks in City

B.C. district council of the Canadian Union of Public Employees met today at the Tally-Ho Hotel to deal with bargaining and strike-backed progress among Greater Victoria and lower mainland locals.

It was a regular meeting of the council, which usually takes place in Vancouver.

Spokesmen for the CUPE area bargaining committee representing striking and locked out civic and school employees in the capital region were not available for comment.

Meanwhile, Capital Regional Board chairman Jim Campbell said a meeting of the regional employers bargaining group set for Monday will be reviewing statements made by CUPE leaders and the employers' position in the light of on-going developments.

Campbell said there is no intention on the part of the group to seek direct intervention by Labor Minister Bill King, in an effort to resolve the present impasse.

"If the labor minister approaches the bargaining group because he is concerned about the failure of the system to produce results — and it must be remembered he is the author of the system — then we would talk to him, of course we would," he said.

FIREMEN DOUSE DRAKE PARTIES

Fire escapes on five unoccupied tenement buildings in Old Town, including the Drake Hotel, were removed Thursday by Victoria fire department to prevent fires resulting from illegal entry.

Firemen have put out three mattress fires in the Drake Hotel in the last two weeks.

Victoria Ald. Sam Bawlf, who owns and plans to restore the properties, said transient people looking for a place to have a "good party" were able to use the escapes to enter the building.

arthur mayse

But It's Just as Well We Never Knew!

NOT LONG BEFORE we removed ourselves from Gordon Head, I discovered where my long-vanished pruning ladder had gone. It was propped against an overgrown Pacific willow tree in the depths of our wild-land acre. By the green mould that coated it, the ladder had obviously leaned there for a number of years.

It was also plain that the ladder had been snitched from our vegetable garden to replace a set of two-by-four ends that suggested their way up the tree trunk to the remains of a tree fort. The irregular spacing of those ads to climbing indicated that once their number had been larger.

This fact in turn suggested that some child, since gone to mum's or woman's estate, had escaped broken bones by one of those miracles without which no active youngster would survive.

Next time we met, I let the furs-bidder know that the mystery of the missing ladder had been solved, and gave him a retroactive chasing out.

"I saw those arrangements on the tree too," I wound up. "It's a wonder you didn't break your necks."

Ron smiled. "One kid almost did," he said. "Funny . . . I hadn't thought about that for years. He was carrying down when the piece he was standing on came loose. Luckily he landed in a bush."

Ron added cheerfully, "That is why we borrowed the pruning ladder."

Up to a point, what parents don't know won't hurt them. I might add to this homely saw that if they were forced to know in full detail, they mightn't survive, either.

Take the time a girl dear to our hearts decided to go for a trail-ride.

We deposited her at a ranch from which guided trail-rides took off for well-bordered excursions into an old logging burn. At intervals during an afternoon of visiting friends on the line, we pictured our darling mounted on a sedate plug on a well-travelled track in the company of a dozen other children. And, naturally, with the watchful guide keeping track of her.

What we didn't know was that the trail-ride had been cancelled, and that Little Miss Silver-Tongue had conned the rancher into letting her head out by her lone.

We picked her up at the appointed time.

— Did she have a nice ride?

It was a lot of fun.

How did her horse behave?

Fine.

Did she see anything interesting?

Lots of things.

And so it went on, through one of those parent-child interviews marked by well-intended evasings and laconic answers.

A month or so later, our chick piped up at dinner:

"Remember that trail ride? I forgot to tell you they let me go out alone. I got lost and a cougar followed us. My horse ran away with me."

I slopped blackberry juice on the table-cloth.

"At least I think it was a cougar," Susan said calmly. "It tagged along beside us in the brush. That was when I was lost on an old grade."

My tape prickled in retrospect.

"My horse got scared. It almost tossed me off."

I asked weakly, "Anything else?"

"Not really. When the horse ran, my lunch got squashed."

Maybe it's a good thing that the course of childhood doesn't always proceed as solicitous parents would have it go. It's even possible that adventures safely sweetened leave a residue of healthy hardhood.

But when I look at a tired eight-foot dingly of which I am now custodian, I'm reminded of unauthorized juvenile voyagings that would have scared me witless had I known of them at the time.

(But I say you could take that boat through the Ten Mile rips?

We had our life-jackets on. Anyway, you didn't say we couldn't.)

Most children manage to outgrow childhood. And it could be that the guardian angel who oversees the process knows what he's about when he spares us the-spot knowledge of all that goes into the growing!

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